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ESPI Insights

SPACE SECTOR WATCH

Commission and SpaceRISE sign IRIS² implementation agreement



Credit: European Commission

The European Commission and the SpaceRISE consortium have signed an implementation agreement moving IRIS² from planning into full-scale deployment. Concluded on 7 August 2026, the agreement closes the Rendezvous 1 negotiations opened in January and confirms the design, system capacity, deployment schedule, target price and level of private investment. The main constellation grows to 348 satellites, comprising 330 in LEO and 18 in MEO, after the addition of a dedicated layer of 66 higher-LEO satellites for defence, security and emergency services. The total programme cost is expected to increase by ~50%, from €10.55B to €15.6B. The Commission expects the reinforcement to raise secure governmental capacity by more than 60%, with first launches still targeted for 2029. For the next steps, the Commission sent an official letter to the European Parliament and EU Member States to inform them of the outcome of the negotiations and the implementation phase. On 31 August, SES also announced that it **awarded OHB a contract worth approximately €1 billion** to develop and manufacture all 18 MEO satellite platforms.

ESA signs first ELC contracts with Isar Aerospace, PLD Space, and RFA

On 27 August 2026, ESA signed the first contracts under the European Launcher Challenge (ELC), committing a combined total of approximately €543M across three European launch service providers, with a fourth contract for MaiaSpace expected to follow in the coming weeks. **Isar Aerospace received the largest award at €197.8M** — mainly funded by Germany with contributions from Austria and Norway — to accelerate development of its Spectrum launch vehicle and expand test and production infrastructure. **PLD Space received €158.9M** — mainly funded by Spain with a German contribution — to develop the Miura 5 launcher capable of delivering up to 540 kg to sun-synchronous orbit from the Guiana Space Centre, alongside planned upgrades for greater payload capacity. **Rocket Factory Augsburg (RFA) received €186.9M** — mainly funded by Germany with a UK contribution — to develop RFA One, a three-stage vehicle targeting 500 kg to 500 km sun-synchronous orbit from SaxaVord Spaceport in the UK. All three companies are required to achieve an orbital launch before 2028 as the ELC's first key milestone.



Credit: ESA

Italy appoints Mario Cospito as extraordinary commissioner to lead ASI

Mario Cospito has been appointed extraordinary commissioner of the Italian Space Agency (ASI), following the dissolution of the agency's board of directors. Following the death of ASI's president Teodoro Valente on 16 July. **On 5 August 2026, three board members resigned** specifically to trigger the appointment of an extraordinary commissioner, as Italian law requires a special administrator once a third of the board is vacant. Cospito is a career diplomat who served as ambassador to Romania, Moldova and Sweden, later worked at Avio, and advised the Minister of Enterprises and Made in Italy on aerospace policy. The appointment is intended to keep ASI operating at full capacity through a period that includes the ESA Ministerial meeting to be held in Italy in December, during the Italian presidency of ESA.

Ariane 6 launches MTG-I2, completing Europe's three-satellite weather constellation



Credit: ESA

On 27 August 2026, Ariane 6 lifted off from the Guiana Space Centre, delivering the Meteosat Third Generation Imager 2 (MTG-I2) satellite in what was the ninth Ariane 6 flight overall and its first to GTO. MTG-I2 completes the first family of two other MTG satellites, launched in 2022 and 2025. MTG-I2 will be positioned in GEO, where it will provide rapid scanning of Europe every 2.5 minutes through its Flexible Combined Imager. The satellite also carries a Lightning Imager capable of detecting individual lightning events by day and night, enabling short-term nowcasting of rapidly evolving weather conditions. Once commissioned, the three-satellite MTG constellation will operate at full capacity, enabling the production of a "weather cube" combining imaging and sounding data to generate three-dimensional representations of atmospheric dynamics, greenhouse gases, and air pollutants.

Bulgaria to build space and defence centre at Dobroslavtsi

The Bulgarian government has signed a MoU to convert the former military airbase at Dobroslavtsi, 15 km from Sofia, into a space and defence research and production centre. The Council of Ministers approved the draft on 5 August 2026 and the memorandum was signed the following day during a site visit by Prime Minister Rumen Radev. The counterparty named by the government is Starbase Europe, a company owned by EnduroSat founder Raycho Raychev, acting as investor and developer under a **public-private partnership**. The three million m² site is to host satellite assembly, testing and qualification alongside research infrastructure, an educational campus and a wider industrial zone, with the runway repaired and kept available to Bulgaria's National Security Service.

US Space Force completes US-Japan SDA initiative and awards several contracts

On 10 August 2026, Japan's H3 rocket launched QZS-7, carrying the second and final US Space Force SDA sensor built by MIT Lincoln Laboratory, completing the QZSS-Hosted Payload programme — the first bilateral US-Japan national security space cooperation effort — and providing near real-time GEO monitoring coverage above the Indo-Pacific.



Credit: United States Space Force

Earlier in the month, Space Force's Space Systems Command (SSC) awarded $615M for the second SB-AMTI task order, split between Rocket Lab ($397M for Flatellites aboard Neutron), STR, and one unnamed awardee, framing the award as vendor diversification after SpaceX's ~$4.2B initial task order in June. **On 13 August, Amazon LEO for Government, Lockheed Martin, Northrop Grumman, Rocket Lab, and York Space Systems each also received $12M to prototype connections to the Space Data Network**, with Rocket Lab testing from its Photon spacecraft in 2027. During the month, Space Force also selected **15 companies to compete for a $981M military space training range competition**, awarded **$22.9M to K2 Space for a laser communications demonstration**, **$93.7M to Firefly's SciTec for ground-based radar modernisation**, a **Firefly Elytra deorbit design contract with the Defence Innovation Unit**, and a **$28M extension to Impulse Space**.

NRO expands use of commercial radar through Capella, ICEYE and Umbra

The US National Reconnaissance Office (NRO) has awarded Radar Commercial Augmentation contracts to Capella Space, ICEYE US and Umbra Lab, expanding operational use of commercial SAR imagery. Announced on 5 August 2026, the contracts run for one year from 1 August with two further one-year options, and give government users a direct route to order collections, archive imagery and derived products. Values were not disclosed. The three were the only companies of five participants to complete the Commercial Radar Capabilities study opened in January 2022. Later in the month, the agency also **awarded HawkEye 360 a Commercial Radio Frequency Capabilities Augmentation contract**, making it the first commercial provider to move from study contracts into an operational role.

Long March fails, but then launches Guowang and UAE payloads



Credit: Andrew Jones

A Long March 7A rocket carrying the ChinaSat-4B communications satellite has broken up shortly after lifting off from Wenchang. The vehicle was destroyed around 85 seconds into flight on 10 August 2026 and the payload was lost. State news agency Xinhua confirmed the failure and said the cause was under investigation. It was the second failure in 18 flights of the Long March 7A, after its 2020 debut, and China's fourth launch failure of 2026. Nevertheless, Long March's flights resumed within a week. On 16 August, a **Long March 12 lifted off from Hainan with the 24th batch of nine Guowang satellites**, taking the constellation to 195 satellites against a 2026 target of 310. The vehicle uses the same YF-100 engine family as the failed rocket, suggesting the anomaly was not engine-related. **A Long March 2C launch followed on 17 August, orbiting an EO satellite for UAE University's National Space Science and Technology Center (NSSTC)**.

South Korea targets Moon landing by 2030 in Seven Major SEED technology strategy

South Korean President Lee Jae Myung announced the "Seven Major SEED" initiative on 12 August 2026 at a Blue House meeting, setting out a national technology strategy centred on seven priority areas: small modular reactors, fusion energy, next-generation renewable energy, quantum technology, space and aviation, advanced biotechnology, and critical minerals and materials supply chains. Within the space pillar, the government targets a domestic Moon landing in 2030, a second lunar lander mission in 2032, and the development of an independent LEO satellite communications network and space data centre technologies by 2035. The 2030 Moon landing goal builds on South Korea's Danuri lunar orbiter mission, launched in 2022, and the roadmap set out by the Korea Aerospace Administration (KASA) at its establishment in 2024.

Rwanda Space Agency and Planet Labs launch national satellite data programme

On 10 August 2026, the Government of Rwanda and Planet Labs have launched a national satellite data programme, managed by the Rwanda Space Agency, marking Planet's first national programme of this kind in Africa. The initiative will provide near-daily satellite imagery and data feeds to government agencies, public universities, selected startups, and strategic development partners supporting Rwanda's national development goals. The programme follows a pilot in Zanzibar supported by the Tony Blair Institute and the World Bank, and positions the Rwanda Space Agency as a central coordinator for satellite-derived data across public institutions.

IN OTHER NEWS

ESA astronaut Sophie Adenot completes first spacewalk

Sophie Adenot has become the first French woman to perform a spacewalk. Working with NASA astronaut Anil Menon on 18 August 2026, she spent six hours and 23 minutes removing a failed Space-to-Ground antenna, returning outside on 25 August to fit the replacement.

CNES seeks partners to mass-produce optical telescopes

CNES is looking for an industrial partner to develop and qualify a compact, low-cost optical telescope for production volumes above 1,000 units. Machined from aluminium to contain costs, it is intended for imaging applications, detection, surveillance and identification, with qualification targeted for 2027 or 2028.

ESA's Draco reentry mission clears CDR ahead of 2027 launch

ESA's Draco mission — a spacecraft designed to record its own fiery atmospheric reentry — passed its Critical Design Review on 17 August 2026, clearing it for full-scale manufacturing and testing, including high-altitude balloon drop tests.

Nigeria approves NIGCOMSAT-2A and 2B satellites

Nigeria's Federal Executive Council approved the acquisition of two next-generation high-throughput communications satellites — NIGCOMSAT-2A (targeted for 2028) and NIGCOMSAT-2B (2029) — on 22 August 2026, to be built by Thales Alenia Space and Israel Aerospace Industries as successors to the ageing NigComSat-1R, for a total value of over $2B.

Türkiye signs Artemis Accords as 71st signatory

Türkiye signed the Artemis Accords on 31 August 2026 at NASA Headquarters in Washington, becoming the 71st signatory. Minister of Industry and Technology Mehmet Fatih Kacır signed on behalf of the country, joined by Turkish Space Agency President Yusuf Kıraç.

Côte d'Ivoire appoints first DG of its national space agency

The government of Côte d'Ivoire has appointed Dr Tidiane Ouattara as inaugural Director General of the Space Agency of Côte d'Ivoire (ASCI), established by June 2025. He continues to serve as President of the African Space Council.

Hisdesat awards SpainSat NG-III contract to Airbus

Spanish Hisdesat has awarded Airbus Defence and Space the role of prime contractor for SpainSat NG-III, completing the industrial structure of a programme that supplies encrypted command-and-control connectivity to the Spanish Armed Forces, government users, NATO and EU GOVSATCOM. The contract tasks Airbus with designing, integrating and testing the satellite and developing its X-band payload in Spain, while **Thales Alenia Space acts as co-contractor**, leading integration and testing of the communications module at Tres Cantos and developing the UHF and military Ka-band payloads. The satellite replaces SpainSat NG-II, declared a total loss after a debris strike during orbit raising. Development is expected to take about 48 months, with launch scheduled for the third quarter of 2030.

ICEYE expands globally with new entities in the Netherlands, India and South Korea

ICEYE established a Netherlands entity based in Amsterdam on 25 August 2026, appointing Joost Elstak as country CEO and launching a technology hub within the Netherlands Defence Technological Industrial Base (NLDTIB), building on the already ICEYE-operated SAR constellation for the Royal Netherlands Air and Space Force. **ICEYE also expanded globally, establishing on 24 August a new entity in New Delhi to support India's defence and intelligence customers and engage with the country's space and defence ecosystem.** The entity will also serve as a platform to build local production capability for defence, surveillance, and environmental monitoring applications through Indian suppliers and workforce. **Finally, on 26 August, ICEYE strengthened its Korean presence by establishing a dedicated local entity with local leadership**, building on its existing partnership with KT SAT and its growing portfolio of government and commercial customers in the region. The three expansions follow ICEYE's establishment of German and Portuguese entities in the last month.

Rocket Lab establishes German entity, wins Neutron contract and launches iQPS

Rocket Lab has established a German subsidiary in Munich to support space capabilities in Europe for satellite manufacturing and launch services in Europe, following the acquisition of Munich-based laser communication manufacturer Mynaric AG earlier this year. Rocket Lab has also been selected **to conduct a dedicated Neutron mission for space infrastructure company Kepler Communications. Launching no earlier than 2028,** the mission will deploy additional satellites for Kepler's LEO constellation from Wallops Island, Virginia.



Credit: Rocket Lab

On the same day, 10 August, **Rocket Lab unveiled GHOST (Global Hypersonic & Orbital Spaceport Technology)**, a containerised launch system designed to support suborbital and orbital launches from multiple locations. The system uses Electron and HASTE rockets and is intended to support multi-launch operations and national security missions. The company plans to establish the first GHOST location in Kodiak, Alaska, with operations expected to begin in 2027.

During the month, Rocket Lab has also completed several launches. On 6 August, **the company launched its 13th Electron rocket of the year, deploying a QPS-SAR satellite for Japanese start-up Institute for Q-shu Pioneers of Space (iQPS)**. On 16 August, Rocket Lab launched the first eight of the 17 satellite platforms for the Canadian company MDA Space aboard, while on 20 August, **it completed a second iQPS mission**, its ninth launch for the Japanese company.

Leonardo DRS and Space42 sign MoU to integrate satellite connectivity

On 12 August 2026, Leonardo DRS — the US subsidiary of the Italian defence group — and UAE-based Space42 signed an MoU to explore the integration of their capabilities for UAE national security applications. Leonardo DRS will contribute its C5ISR mission systems expertise, including tactical computing and AI-enabled processing, while Space42 will provide secure satellite communications and Beyond Line of Sight (BLOS) connectivity. The two companies will jointly study the design and integration of advanced mission capabilities for UAE sovereign defence requirements, combining space-based connectivity with ground-based mission systems to extend situational awareness beyond terrestrial network coverage.

Spanish Kreios Space selects Kongsberg NanoAvionics for VLEO demonstration

On 4 August 2026, Spanish satellite startup Kreios Space has selected Kongsberg NanoAvionics' MP42 microsatellite bus for its first in-orbit demonstration of air-breathing electric propulsion (ABEP). The approximately 200 kg spacecraft will launch in 2028, drifting from 300 km down to 150 km while firing the ABEP thruster at different altitudes over a six-to-ten-month mission window, and also carrying a sub-metre resolution optical payload. NanoAvionics will customise the MP42 bus to handle VLEO aerodynamic torques, perform full system testing and commission the satellite before handing operational control to Kreios. The mission will be one of the first ABEP-based VLEO flights.

SpaceX unveils Starbase, Louisiana as a new ten-pad Starship spaceport



Credit: SpaceX

SpaceX unveiled plans on 25 August 2026 for Starbase, Louisiana, a new Starship launch facility at Pecan Island in Vermilion Parish on the Louisiana Gulf Coast, described as the largest private spaceport in the world. The site will span 125,000 acres — comparable in scale to Cape Canaveral and Kennedy Space Center combined — and will feature ten Starship launch pads arranged in five double-pad pairs, a full-scale production facility, on-site propellant production, and power generation infrastructure. SpaceX plans to invest $100B in the site, including coastal restoration and wetland reinforcement, with construction beginning in 2027 and a first Starship launch targeted for 2029.

Chinese Zhuque-3 completes second flight with first-stage landing

On 18 August 2026, the Chinese company Landspace has completed the second flight of its Zhuque-3 rocket, successfully landing its first stage after launch from the Gobi Desert. The 66-metre first stage completed a powered descent and vertical landing approximately 390km downrange in Minqin County, Gansu Province. **The booster later tipped over after a post-landing fire damaged one of its landing legs, preventing the planned re-flight.** The landing makes Zhuque-3 one of only four orbital-class rockets to have successfully recovered a first stage.



Credit: Landspace

Firefly Aerospace extends Lockheed Martin agreement and signs lunar partnership



Credit: Firefly Aerospace

On 11 August 2026, Firefly Aerospace has extended its multi-launch agreement with Lockheed Martin for two years, allowing up to 25 Alpha Block II rocket launches through 2031. The Block II configuration is designed to support tactically responsive space missions, hypersonic testing, and commercial satellite launches for domestic and international customers.

Later in the month, **Firefly Aerospace has also partnered with the US company Zeno Power Systems to carry its "Survive-the-Night" package** with a Radioisotope Heater Unit on a lunar mission to the Moon's near side, scheduled for no earlier than 2028. The mission aims to demonstrate Zeno's technologies for enabling spacecraft and lunar infrastructure to operate during the lunar night.

Starlink expands in Africa through Airtel DRC and Paratus Uganda

On 14 August 2026, Airtel Africa launched Africa's first commercial satellite-to-device service in the Democratic Republic of Congo, in partnership with Starlink, building on a strategic agreement signed in December 2025 and a pilot conducted in Kenya in March 2026. The DRC is the first of Airtel Africa's 14 African markets to commercialise D2D service, with rollout to other markets subject to country-specific regulatory approvals and Apple device support expected to be added later.

On the broadband side, Paratus Uganda — a joint venture between Paratus Group and Kampala-based ROKE TELKOM — became the first licensed Starlink service provider in Uganda on 24 August, following the signing of an operational licence agreement between the Uganda Communications Commission and Starlink on 15 May 2026. The service targets enterprise customers in mining, healthcare, tourism, and government sectors requiring connectivity in remote and underserved areas, and represents Paratus Group's ninth African country to offer Starlink services.

MDA Space deploys Globalstar's replenishment satellites



Credit: MDA Space

On 15 August 2026, MDA Space has deployed the initial eight replenishment satellites for Globalstar's existing LEO constellation aboard a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket from Cape Canaveral, Florida. The satellites will undergo in-orbit testing before entering service, while the remaining nine satellites on order are in the final stages of integration at MDA Space. The constellation is MDA Space's first constellation delivered as a prime contractor.

Australian HEO and Planet Labs integrate SkySat satellites into SDA network



Credit: HEO

On 18 August 2026, **Australian non-Earth imaging company HEO and Planet Labs announced a partnership to integrate Planet's SkySat high-resolution satellite constellation into HEO's Non-Earth Imaging (NEI) SDA network**, expanding it to over 50 in-orbit sensors. The agreement harnesses previously unused SkySat capacity without interfering with the satellites' primary Earth observation missions, with HEO's proprietary software handling automated tasking, collection coordination, and analytics.

IN OTHER NEWS

Space Norway appoints acting CEO

On 19 August 2026, Space Norway has named Rune Jensen as acting Chief Executive Officer, effective 1 September. Current CEO Morten Tengs steps down on the same date to take up the role of Special Adviser.

ICEYE appoints UAE Chief Executive Officer

ICEYE has appointed Christos Kolimenakis as CEO of ICEYE UAE to lead its operations and partnerships in the country. He joins ICEYE from JPMorgan, where he spent 15 years as Managing Director for the UAE.

Edge Aerospace licenses Redwire for satellite data processors

Luxembourg-based Edge Aerospace signed a licensing agreement with Redwire on 25 August 2026 for Redwire to manufacture Edge's data processing units and network switches at its Marlborough, Massachusetts facility, with first deliveries expected in Q1 2027.

EarthEye Space and IN2 partner to integrate satellite analytics

Singapore-based EarthEye Space and London-based strategic communications firm IN2 signed an MoU to integrate EarthEye's multi-sensor satellite tasking and analytics into IN2's consulting for government, defence, and enterprise clients, initially focusing on infrastructure monitoring, disaster response, and environmental surveillance.

Astranis develops a space domain awareness GEO satellite

On 13 August 2026, the US-based company Astranis has unveiled Perceptor, a satellite designed to provide SDA and manoeuvrability in GEO. The satellite will also conduct flybys to assess other spacecraft capabilities, help troubleshoot anomalies on allied spacecraft, and extend monitoring capabilities in GEO.

United Launch Alliance appoints new CEO

On 17 August 2026, ULA has named aerospace executive Mark Peller as President and Chief Executive Officer, effective immediately. He succeeds John Elbon, who has served as interim CEO since December.

SpaceSail raises €894M capital to expand Qianfan LEO constellation

Chinese satellite communications company SpaceSail raised ¥6.98B (approx. €894M) through a capital increase, valuing the company at ¥50B (approx. €6.4B). The transaction marks the largest financing round in China's commercial space sector and will support the expansion of the company's Qianfan LEO satellite constellation, strengthening the country's satellite communications capabilities. Approximately 80% of SpaceSail remains in the hands of state-linked shareholders, led by Shanghai Alliance Investment, holding the largest stake at 49.9%. The Qianfan constellation has been allocated spectrum and orbital positions for up to 15,000 satellites, but SpaceSail must meet deployment targets to retain these rights, with a key deadline falling in 2027-2028. One of the company's latest milestones came in June, when the company's DTCC-01 satellite powered China's first direct-to-cell voice calls using commercial smartphones.

K2 Space secures $500M to expand satellite production



Credit: K2 Space

The US startup K2 Space closed a $500M Series D funding round on July 30, reaching a $6.8B valuation. Led by Kleiner Perkins and ICONIQ, the funding will support the expansion of the company's manufacturing capacity as it targets production of up to 100 satellites annually. The company is pursuing a vertically integrated manufacturing strategy aiming to reduce production times. Just eight months after its previous funding round, the company has surpassed $1 billion in both government and commercial contracts. Key programs include the MeoSphere MEO constellation for Luxembourg-based operator SES, as well as US defence programmes such as Golden Dome and Protected Tactical Satcom-Global.

Rocketdyne returns as independent space company following L3Harris carve-out

Rocketdyne, US supplier of rocket engines and spacecraft propulsion systems, has returned as an independent company following AE Industrial Partners' acquisition of a 60% stake in L3Harris' space business unit. With this transaction, AE Industrial Partners intends to use Rocketdyne's established space heritage as a platform for further investment in propulsion – including upgrading the RL10 rocket engine – and nuclear power capabilities for future missions. The transaction also reflects L3Harris's decision to separate its space propulsion activities from its growing missile business, establishing Rocketdyne as a standalone company while retaining a 40% stake. The business had been part of L3Harris since its 2023 acquisition of Aerojet Rocketdyne.

Lynk and Omnispace complete D2D merger under Elveo Mobile


Credit: Elveo

US-based Satellite operators **Lynk and Omnispace have completed their merger to launch Elveo Mobile**, combining their satellite spectrum rights and direct-to-device (D2D) technologies into a single operator. The company will provide connectivity to consumers through partnerships with mobile network operators, using a planned constellation of 320 LEO satellites. Satellite launches are expected to begin in late 2027. SES is one of Elveo's key shareholders, both through its **prior investment in Lynk** before the merger and **through its acquisition of Intelsat**, which held a stake in Omnispace. Elveo also **received a $20M strategic investment from Nelco, a subsidiary of Tata Group**, and plans to leverage the partnership to expand into India and other South Asian markets.

Hughes enters financial restructuring as GEO business comes under pressure



Credit: Hughes Satellite Systems

Hughes Satellite Systems, a subsidiary of EchoStar, filed for financial restructuring after defaulting on approximately $1.5B in debt. Negotiations with creditors, who hold around 80% of the debt, failed amid allegations that EchoStar forced the company into unfavourable financing arrangements. The bankruptcy prompted the company to reposition its operations toward the government and defence markets, with the increasing competition arising from LEO satellite constellations. According to the company, the process will not result in the liquidation of the US based business and customer services will continue without interruption.

China's iSpace raises Series E first tranche amid IPO prospects

iSpace has secured the first tranche of its ongoing Series E funding round, raising approximately $148M to accelerate development of its reusable launch vehicle program. The funding comes amid local media reports that iSpace is targeting a listing on Shanghai's STAR Market in the second half of 2027 following the expected debut of Hyperbola 3, a two-stage reusable launch vehicle powered by methane and liquid oxygen propulsion. The first tranche of Series E funding was led by Asset Investment Companies (AICs) affiliated with China's major state-owned banks. iSpace plans to use the funds toward manufacturing and qualification of Hyperbola 3.

Muon Space raises $250M Series C round to scale satellite manufacturing

Muon Space, a US satellite manufacturer, has raised $250M in a Series C round led by Eclipse Capital, bringing the company's total equity funding to more than $386M and valuing it at approximately $1.5B. The funding will support the expansion of Muon's satellite manufacturing capabilities, with the target production of up to 500 satellites annually by 2027 at its new San Jose facility. Muon has deployed 11 satellites across six launches and is currently developing more than 50 additional satellites for customers.



Credit: Muon Space

Starcloud closes $250M round to build orbital data centers

On 24 August 2026, the US company Starcloud has secured $250M in an extension of its Series A round at a post-money valuation of $2.3B. Manhattan West led the financing, with NVIDIA and Cisco Investments joining existing investors including Benchmark and EQT. The new financing will support the development of larger orbital computing systems needed to run high-performance GPUs in space. The company previously demonstrated AI model training in space and ran Google's Gemini on its orbital computing hardware.

Ursa Major to go public through SPAC deal

Ursa Major Technology, a rocket engine company, plans to go public through a SPAC merger with Bleichroeder Acquisition Corp. III, backed by Inflection Point Asset Management. Expected to close in Q1 2027, the transaction values Ursa Major at approximately $2.3 billion and is expected to raise at least $350M. The company will focus on the defence market, supplying critical munitions while leveraging its hypersonic and solid rocket motor manufacturing expertise.

IN OTHER NEWS

Orienspace raises new funding as it prepares for potential IPO

Chinese launch startup has raised a Pre-C funding round to support the development of its reusable Gravity-2 rocket. Orienspace has also begun preparations for IPO counselling, with a potential listing on the Shanghai Stock Exchange's STAR Market.

Tianhui Aerospace raises Series B funding for reusable rockets

China's startup Shaanxi Tianhuí Aerospace Technology has completed a Series B financing, which will support its ongoing projects for reusable liquid launch vehicle engines and commercial launch vehicles.

Neuraspace raises €6M for autonomous satellite operations

Portuguese company Neuraspace raised €6M from private investors Lince Capital, Explorer Investments and Armilar Venture Partners. The equity funding was paired with €9.6M in grants from Portugal's Recovery and Resilience Plan. The company develops software for satellite monitoring and will use the new funding to further develop these operations.

Chinese startup Lightyear Exploration raises Pre-A+ funding

Lightyear Exploration has recently completed a Pre-A+ equity financing round worth millions of yuan, led by Jiantou Investment and Dingxin Capital, bringing its cumulative funding above ¥100M (approx. €12.8M). The business is focused on developing structural components for commercial rockets, including propellant tanks.

Japanese startup Letara advances hybrid rocket technology

Letara has closed a Pre-Series A round of approximately $16M co-led by Headline Asia, JIC Venture Growth Investments and Incubate Fund, alongside other investors. The new funding will support the development and commercialisation of its hybrid rocket propulsion system.

GalaxEye acquires StarOps for its satellite capabilities

The Indian company GalaxEye has acquired the Indian-based startup StarOps to develop its EO satellite capabilities. The acquisition will support the development of GalaxEye's OptoSar constellation and increase its vertical integration across the satellite value chain.

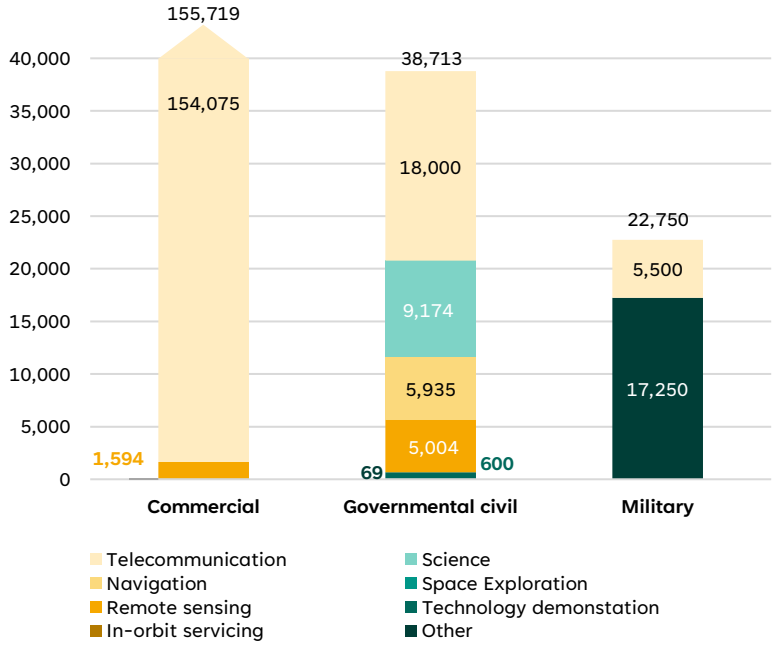
LAUNCHES & PAYLOAD – AUGUST 2026

Launch provider's region	USA	China	Europe	Russia	India	Japan	Others (NZ)	Total
Number of launches	14	7	1	1	0	1	2	**26**
Number of spacecraft launched	296	30	1	1	0	1	2	**331**
Mass launched (in kg)	180,499	26,817	3,800	935	0	5,000	200	**217,251**

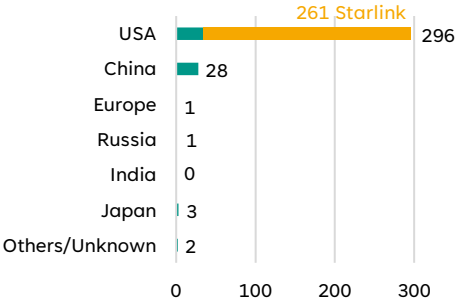
Top launch service providers of the month

1. SpaceX (14)
2. CASC (4)
3. Rocket Lab (2)

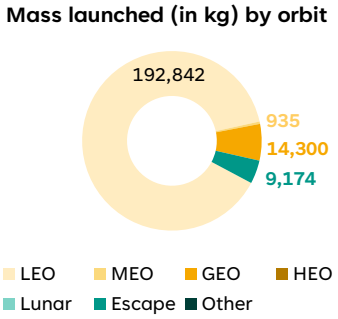
Mass launched (in kg) by market and by mission

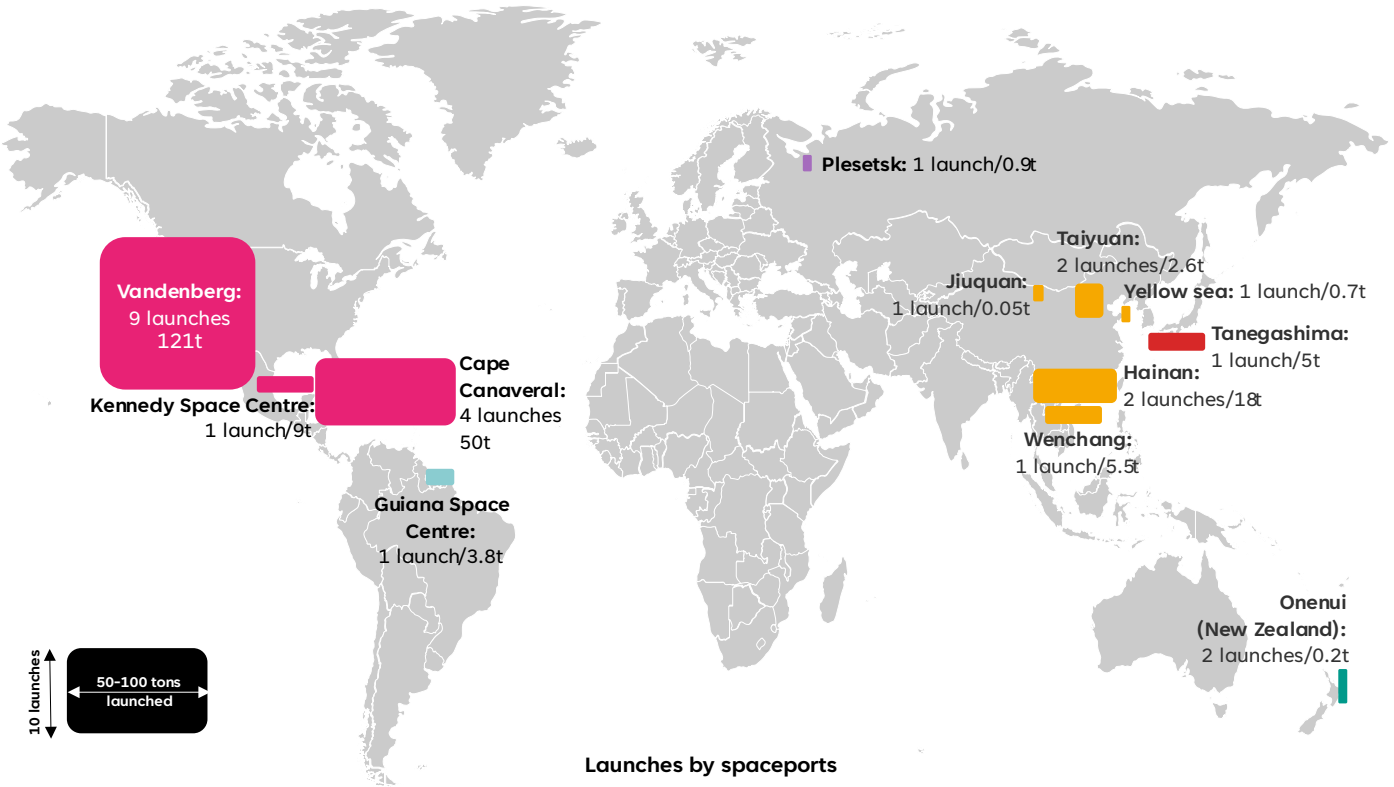


Number of spacecraft launched by payload owner's region



Mass launched (in kg) by orbit





Launches by spaceports

*The data is an estimation from ESPI's internal launches dataset, publicly accessible through the **ESPI Launch Dashboard**.*

ESPI Insights

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